Amtrak Rail Pass

This summer, I plan to use the Amtrak Rail Pass to travel for 1 month. This blog will contain my plans for the journey, and my thoughts on each day's experiences.
The following map gives an overview of the approximate Amtrak routes across the U.S. Chicago is the center of the rail network.

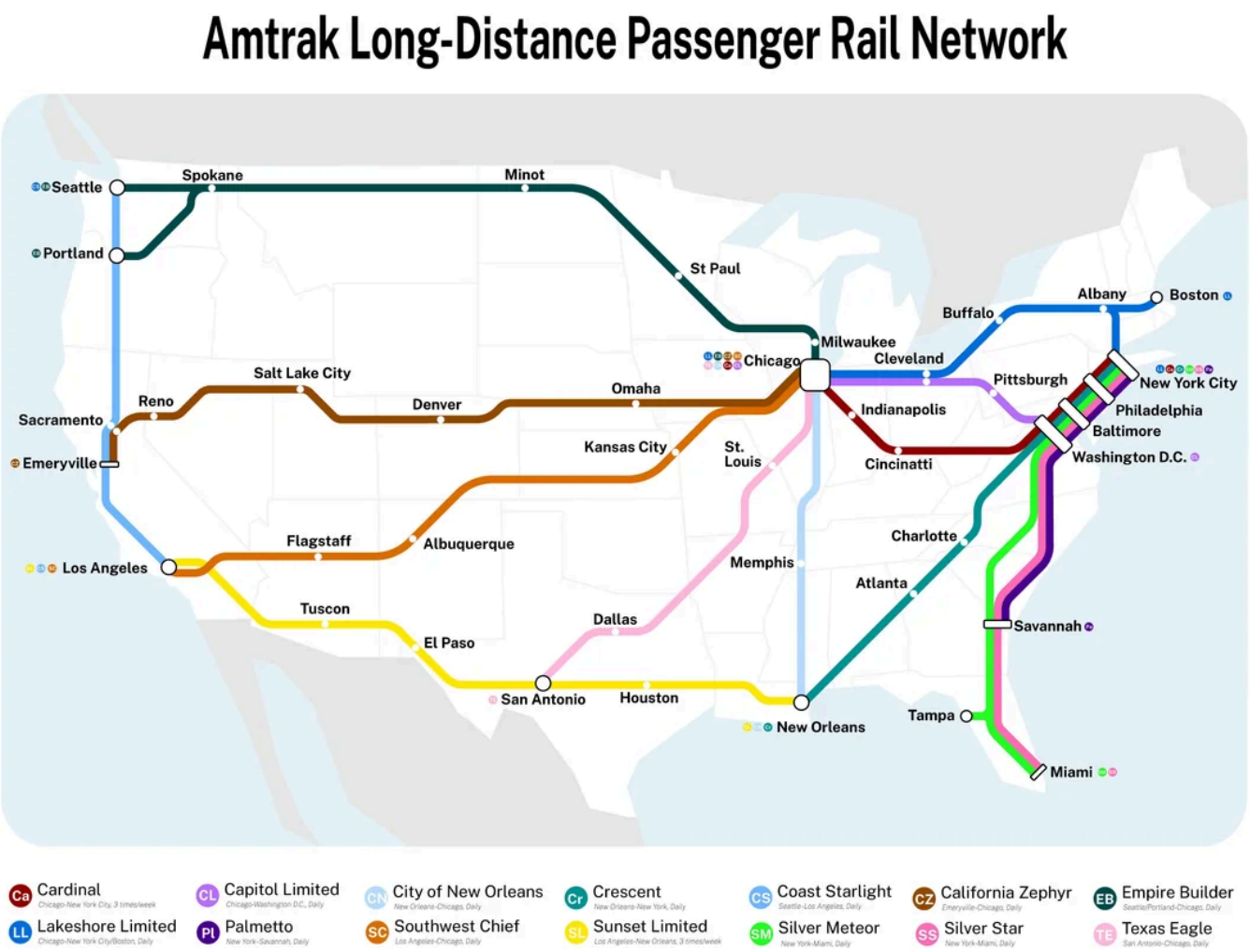

Figure 1: Amtrak Route Map [1]

Itinerary

Currently, the itinerary of cities is

- Marshall, Texas -> Chicago (Texas Eagle) April 25@9:30pm-26@4:15pm
- Chicago -> Boston (Lakeshore Limited) April 26@9:30pm-27@8:30pm
- Boston -> New York City (Lakeshore Limited) April 30@3:15pm-7:45pm
- New York City -> Philadelphia (Vermonter) May 5@6:45pm-8:15pm
- Philadelpha -> Washington D.C. (Northeast Regional) May 8@1:47pm-3:45pm
- Washington D.C. -> Chicago (Floridian) May 11th@3:57pm-May 12@8:45am
- Chicago -> Seattle (Empire Builder) May 12@3pm-May 14@11:30am
- Seattle -> Emeryville (Coast Starlight) May 17@9:45am-May 18@8:30pm
- Emeryville -> Chicago (California Zephyr) May 20@8:15am-22@2:45pm
- Chicago -> Dallas (Texas Eagle) May 23@2pm-May 24@12pm

Boston - April 27th-30th

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
Day 1 – Apr 28	9:00 AM	Boston Common	FREE	Start here

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Morning	Public Garden	FREE	Swan Boats seasonal
	Morning	Beacon Hill Friends House	FREE	Brief stop
	Mid-Morning	Freedom Trail (2.5 mi)	FREE	Follow red brick path
	Mid-Morning	Park Street Church	FREE	Along trail
	Mid-Morning	Granary Burying Ground	FREE	Along trail
	Mid-Morning	King’s Chapel	FREE	Along trail
	Lunch	Faneuil Hall & Quincy Market	FREE	Browse & eat
	Afternoon	Paul Revere House	$5.50	
	Afternoon	Old North Church	$5	
	Evening	Rose Kennedy Greenway	FREE	Neighborhood stroll
	Evening	Beacon Hill	FREE	End near South Station
Day 2 — Apr 29	Morning	Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum	$15	2–3 hours (Fenway)
	Afternoon	Harvard Art Museums	FREE	Student ID; take T from Fenway
	Afternoon	Harvard Square + Harvard Yard	FREE	Walk around after museums
Day 3 — Apr 30	Morning	Newbury Street	FREE	Shopping/dining
	Morning	Trinity Church	FREE	Back Bay, 30 min
	Morning	Boston Public Library	FREE	Back Bay, 30 min
	Afternoon	Seaport District	FREE	Restaurants & browsing
	3:15 PM	**Depart South Station**	—	Seaport is a short walk to South Station

New York City - April 30th-May 5th

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
Apr 30	Evening	Arrive Queens	—	Check in, rest
Day 1 — May 1 (Manhattan)	Morning	Times Square	FREE	Less crowded early
	Morning	New York Public Library	FREE	
	Mid-Morning	Grand Central Station	FREE	
	Mid-Morning	Rockefeller Center	FREE	Exterior
	Afternoon	AMNH	Pay-what-you-wish	Can pay $1 w/ student ID
	Afternoon	Central Park	FREE	Walk through after AMNH
	Evening	Greenwich Village	FREE	Dinner & wander
Day 2 — May 2 (Manhattan)	Morning	5th Avenue + St. Patrick’s Cathedral	FREE	Start midtown, walk north
	Mid-Morning	Museum Mile (82nd–105th St)	—	All on 5th Ave

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Mid-Morning	The Met	Pay-what-you-wish	Can pay $1 w/ student ID
	Mid-Morning	El Museo del Barrio	**FREE**	Students free
	Mid-Morning	Museum of the City of New York	**FREE**	Students free
	Afternoon	Guggenheim	**$18**	Student ID
	Evening	MoMA	**FREE**	Free every Fri 5:30–9pm
Day 3 — May 3 (Queens)	Morning	Flushing Chinatown	FREE	Best cheap food in NYC
	Afternoon	Flushing Meadows-Corona Park	FREE	USTA, Queens Museum nearby
	Evening	Jackson Heights	FREE	Little India — great cheap eats
	Evening	Queens Night Market	FREE	
Day 4 — May 4 (Brooklyn)	Morning	Brooklyn Botanic Garden	~$15	Free Tues & select Sat mornings
	Midday	Prospect Park	FREE	Adjacent to BBG
	Afternoon	DUMBO	FREE	Great Manhattan Bridge views
	Afternoon	Walk Brooklyn Bridge	FREE	Brooklyn→Manhattan side
	Evening	Little Italy	FREE	Dinner on the way back
Day 5 — May 5 (Queens AM)	Morning	Explore local Queens neighborhood	FREE	Easy since you're staying there
	Mid-Morning	Statue of Liberty — Battery Park or Staten Island Ferry	FREE	Ferry is free + closer views
	6:49 PM	**Depart NYC**	—	

Philadelphia - May 5th-May 8th

Figure 2: Map of Philadelphia's Murals

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
May 5	8:07 PM	Arrive Philadelphia	—	Grab food near hotel; Reading Terminal closes ~6pm
Day 1 — May 6 (Old City)	Morning	Liberty Bell	**FREE**	NPS; no tickets needed
	Morning	Independence Hall	**FREE**	Free timed-entry — book at recreation.gov in advance
	Mid-Morning	Free Quaker Meeting House	**FREE**	Steps from Independence Hall
	Mid-Morning	Arch Street Meeting House	Free/donation	Oldest continuously used meetinghouse in the US
	Mid-Morning	Elfreth’s Alley	**FREE**	Oldest residential street in the US; very photogenic
	Midday	Reading Terminal Market	FREE to enter	Lunch; $8–15 for a full meal
	Afternoon	Delaware River Waterfront	**FREE**	Penn’s Landing, scenic walk
	Evening	Old City murals / wander	**FREE**	Philly has some of the best street art in the US
Day 2 — May 7 (South Philly + Center City)	Morning	Italian Market	**FREE**	Oldest open-air market in the US; great cheap eats
	Mid-Morning	Magic Gardens	**~$10**	Student discount; Isaiah Zagar mosaic art on South Street
	Midday	South Street	**FREE**	Wander, lunch, shops
	Afternoon	Rittenhouse Square	**FREE**	Beautiful park, upscale neighborhood
	Afternoon	City Hall	**FREE**	Walk around; observation tower ~$8
	Evening	Fishtown	**FREE**	Hip neighborhood, great cheap dinner spots
Day 3 — May 8 (Parkway Morning)	Morning	Benjamin Franklin Parkway	**FREE**	Outdoor scenic boulevard
	Mid-Morning	Philadelphia Museum of Art	**~$14**	Student ID; Rocky steps are always free
	1:47 PM	**Depart Philadelphia**	—	

Washington D.C. - May 8th-May 11th

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
Day 1 — May 8 (Thu)	3:45 PM	Arrive DC	—	Check in, freshen up
	5:30 PM	Embassy Row	FREE	Stroll Massachusetts Ave NW
	Evening	Dupont Circle	FREE	Dinner, neighborhood walk
Day 2 — May 9 (Fri)	8:00 AM	Arlington National Cemetery	FREE	Tomb of Unknown Soldier, 2–3 hrs
	↳	Arlington House	FREE	Along the way
	Midday	Cross Memorial Bridge	—	Walk or rideshare to the Mall
	Afternoon	Smithsonian Museums	FREE	Pick 2–3: Air & Space, Natural History, American History
	Late Afternoon	Library of Congress	FREE	Thomas Jefferson Building tour
	Evening	Navy Yard / The Yards	FREE	Waterfront bars & dinner
Day 3 — May 10 (Sat)	Morning	Rockville	FREE	Pike & Rose area, downtown Rockville
	↳	Metro back	—	Red Line
	Afternoon	Baltimore (with Narein)	Varies	MARC train from Union Station (~45 min, $9)
	↳	Inner Harbor / Fell’s Point	FREE	Explore with Narein
	Evening	Return to DC	—	MARC back to Union Station
Day 4 — May 11 (Sun)	9:00 AM	Mount Vernon	$28	Drive/rideshare ~30 min south
	11:30 AM	Old Town Alexandria	FREE	King Street, waterfront stroll
	↳	Lunch	Varies	King Street restaurant row
	2:00 PM	Head back to DC	—	Metro (King St–Old Town Blue/Yellow)
	4:00 PM	**Depart DC**	—	

Seattle - May 14-May 17

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
May 14 — Arrive 11:30am	Afternoon	Pike Place Market + Original Starbucks	FREE to enter	1912 Pike Place; expect a line
	Afternoon	Seattle Waterfront / Pier 57	FREE	Walk along the water

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Afternoon	Pioneer Square	FREE	Oldest neighborhood in Seattle
	Evening	Capitol Hill	FREE	Best food/ nightlife neighborhood
Day 2 — May 15	Morning	Kerry Park	FREE	Best Space Needle + skyline view
	Morning	Seattle Center grounds	FREE	Space Needle exterior, fountain
	Mid-Morning	Chihuly Garden and Glass	~$27	Student ID
	Midday	International District	FREE	Cheap lunch
	Afternoon	Fremont + Fremont Troll	FREE	Canal views
	Afternoon	Gas Works Park	FREE	Great lake views
Day 3 — May 16	Morning	Seattle Art Museum	~$15	Student ID
	Mid-Morning	Seattle Public Library	FREE	Architecturally stunning inside
	Midday	Ballard neighborhood	FREE	Fishermen’s Terminal, Ballard Locks (free)
	Afternoon	University of Washington campus	FREE	Beautiful quad, free to walk
	Evening	Last dinner in Capitol Hill	—	
May 17	By 9:55 AM	Depart Seattle	—	

San Francisco - May 18-May 20

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
May 18 — Arrive 8:30am	Morning	Ferry Building	FREE	Great breakfast, farmers market on Sat
	Morning	Embarcadero / Waterfront walk	FREE	
	Mid-Morning	Chinatown	FREE	Walk through, cheap eats
	Midday	North Beach	FREE	City Lights Bookstore, Beat Generation neighborhood
	Midday	Lombard Street	FREE	
	Afternoon	Coit Tower	FREE exterior	Views nearly as good from outside
	Afternoon	Fisherman’s Wharf	FREE to wander	
	Evening	Mission District + Mission Style Burrito@La Cumbre	FREE	Best cheap food in SF; Dolores Park stroll
Day 2 — May 19	Morning	Golden Gate Bridge	FREE	Walk across

Day	Time	Stop	Cost	Notes
	Mid-Morning	Golden Gate Park	FREE	
	↳	de Young Museum	~$15	Student ID; free first Tues of month
	Midday	Haight-Ashbury	FREE	Historic counterculture neighborhood
	Afternoon	SFMOMA	~$19	Free last Thursday evening
	Evening	Castro District	FREE	Iconic neighborhood, great food
May 20	By 8:30 AM	Depart SF	—	Pack the night before

Pizza List

The most iconic pizzas from each city are:

City	Style	Where	Est. Cost
Boston	Thin crust New England	Regina Pizzeria (North End)	~$4/slice
NYC	Classic NY dollar slice + Sicilian Pizza	Luigi's Pizza + L&P Spumoni Gardens	~$2–3/slice
Philadelphia	Tomato pie (no cheese)	Santucci's or Lorenzo's	~$8–12
DC	Jumbo slice	Any Adams Morgan spot	~$4–5
Seattle	No iconic style	Ballard Pizza Co. or similar	~$4/slice
SF	Sourdough crust	Tony's Pizza Napoletana	~$5/slice
Chicago	Deep Dish + Tavern Style	Pizzeria Uno + Pizz'Amici	~$5/slice

Packing List

Essentials

- ☑ Hiking Bag
- ☑ Water Bottle
- ☑ Sleeping Bag
- ☑ Drawstring Bag

Clothing

Essentials

- ☑ 3 Pants
- ☑ 3 Undershirt
- ☑ 3 Athletic T-Shirts
- ☑ 4 Socks
- ☑ 4 Underwear
- ☑ Windbreaker
- ☑ Shoes

Extra

- ☑ Emergency Poncho
- ☑ Umbrella

- ☑ Needle/Thread

Toiletries

- ☑ Towel
- ☑ Toothbrush/Toothpaste
- ☑ Tongue Cleaner
- ☑ Mouth Guard
- ☑ Deodorant
- ☑ Comb
- ☑ Beard Trimmer
- ☑ First Aid Kit
- ☑ Sunscreen
- ☑ Hand sanitizer
- ☑ Wet Wipes

Electronics

- ☑ Phone/Charger
- ☑ Laptop/Charger
- ☑ Earbuds/Charger
- ☑ Batteries
- ☑ Trackers

Food

Grocery Items

- ☑ Granola
- ☑ Nuts
- ☑ Cheese
- ☑ Dried Fruit
- ☑ Chocolate

Other

- ☑ Playing Cards
- ☑ Driver's License
- ☑ Pictures of Passport
- ☑ Credit/Debit Card
- ☑ Tickets

Daily Updates

Day 1 - April 25 (Sat)

Today was a surprisingly relaxed day. I fell asleep around midnight and woke up around 7 (a little shorter than I would have liked, but restful nontheless). I got ready and picked up Rina from UTD, and we got cookies from Hug Cafe in downtown McKinney. I probably never would have heard about it if it weren't from a coupon I received in the mail, but honestly it may be worth revisiting. The food was good, but more compellingly the restaurant provides employment to primarily people with intellectual disabilities. I came home and had paneer fried rice with Rina, then went to Swig for a small treat. We lost track of time a little, but made it home by 4 to leave for Marshall. I tried Chili's for the first time on the drive over, and Rina and I both ordered the veggies burger. It was alright, although there was nothing exemplary about it. I am excited for her move towards flex/veg-itarianism. It definitely will be challenging for her, but I also think it will be very rewarding. Overall, it was just nice being able to spend time with my

family and one of my best friends, and I am looking forward to more days of just time to spend idly with Rina and Rino over the summer. I hope Rina has time when I go to D.C., but I am not holding my breath since its finals season. This does feel like the right time to travel though. Logically, I have the most time now, but I am also reminded of Ibn Batuta's words as well: "travelling - it gives you home in a thousand strange places, then leaves you a stranger in your own land". I hope this journey gives me a new lens on America, and I hope I come to appreciate my friends and family and home here even more. Until I got onto the train, I hadn't really contemplated the magnitude of the trip, but 30 days of constat travel is a long time, and more intense than even my 3 weeks of travel in India in December '24. I am a bit nervous, but also very excited. But first, as I write this, its probably time to sleep. The seats seem reasonably comfortable, and definitely more than I was expecting. Overall, today was a great start to what is hopefully a great trip.

Day 2 - April 26 (Sun)

Day 3 - April 27 (Mon)

Day 4 - April 28 (Tue)

Day 5 - April 29 (Wed)

Day 6 - April 30 (Thu)

Day 7 - May 1 (Fri)

Day 8 - May 2 (Sat)

Day 9 - May 3 (Sun)

Day 10 - May 4 (Mon)

Day 11 - May 5 (Tue)

Day 12 - May 6 (Wed)

Day 13 - May 7 (Thu)

Day 14 - May 8 (Fri)

Day 15 - May 9 (Sat)

Day 16 - May 10 (Sun)

Day 17 - May 11 (Mon)

Day 18 - May 12 (Tue)

Day 19 - May 13 (Wed)

Day 20 - May 14 (Thu)

Day 21 - May 15 (Fri)

Day 22 - May 16 (Sat)

Day 23 - May 17 (Sun)

Day 24 - May 18 (Mon)

Day 25 - May 19 (Tue)

Day 26 - May 20 (Wed)

Day 27 - May 21 (Thu)

Day 28 - May 22 (Fri)

Day 29 - May 23 (Sat)

Day 30 - May 24 (Sun)

Tickets

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Bibliography

[1] caliberal, "A map I made showing the Amtrak long-distance routes." 2023.